



Depression (Depressive Disorder)

Depression is a common mental disorder that differs from occasionally feeling sad or unhappy and affects a person's mood, thoughts, and daily life. Everyone may experience sadness, stress, or low mood from time to time. However, in depression, this condition is not temporary; a depressed mood or a loss of interest and pleasure in activities that were previously enjoyable persists for at least two weeks, for most of the day, nearly every day. These symptoms can significantly affect a person's school, work, family, and social life.

Depression can occur in people of all ages and from different life circumstances. It is estimated to affect hundreds of millions of people worldwide and is more common in women than in men. However, depression may be more difficult to recognize in men. In some men, symptoms such as anger, restlessness, social withdrawal, increased engagement in risky behaviors, or increased alcohol and substance use may be more prominent than sadness. In children and adolescents, depression may not always appear as obvious sadness; instead, it may manifest as irritability, problems at school, restlessness, or social withdrawal.

There is no single cause of depression. The interaction of biological, psychological, and social factors plays a role in the development of the disorder. Unemployment, significant loss, traumatic experiences, prolonged stress, and social difficulties may increase the risk of depression. In addition, genetic characteristics, certain biological processes, and an individual's environment may also contribute. Depression is also closely associated with physical illnesses. Health conditions such as cardiovascular disease, diabetes, cancer, and chronic pain may increase the risk of depression; conversely, depression may negatively affect a person's physical health and make it more difficult to cope with existing health conditions.

The symptoms of depression may vary from person to person. The most common symptoms include persistent feelings of sadness, emptiness, or hopelessness; loss of interest in or pleasure from previously enjoyable activities; fatigue and decreased energy; difficulties with concentration and decision-making; sleep disturbances; changes in appetite and weight; and feelings of guilt, worthlessness, or helplessness. Some individuals may also experience headaches, digestive problems, or unexplained physical pain. In more severe cases, thoughts of death or suicide may occur. Therefore, depression should not be regarded merely as feeling down or having a low mood; it should be considered a serious health condition that can affect a person's life and safety.

Depression can occur in different forms. Major depression is generally characterized by depressive symptoms that last for at least two weeks and significantly affect daily functioning. Persistent depressive disorder

(dysthymia) refers to depressive symptoms that persist for a longer period and are generally milder but more continuous. Other forms include depression with seasonal features, depression accompanied by psychotic symptoms, and depressive conditions associated with pregnancy and the postpartum period. In bipolar disorder, depressive episodes occur together with periods of mania or hypomania, which are characterized by an unusually elevated or expansive mood and increased energy or activity. Therefore, when evaluating depression, it is important to consider the individual's previous episodes of mood changes as well.

Depression is not diagnosed based on a single symptom alone. A healthcare professional evaluates when the symptoms began, how long they have lasted, the extent to which they affect daily functioning, and whether other health conditions are present. Since certain medications and medical conditions, such as thyroid disorders, can cause symptoms similar to those of depression, a physical examination and various tests may be performed when necessary.

Depression is a treatable disorder. Treatment is planned according to the severity of the symptoms, the individual's needs, and personal preferences. Psychotherapy is an important treatment option, particularly for mild depression. Approaches such

as cognitive behavioral therapy and interpersonal therapy can help individuals recognize negative thought and behavioral patterns, develop healthier ways of coping with problems, and improve their relationships. In moderate and severe depression, antidepressant medications may be used in combination with psychotherapy. In some cases that do not respond adequately to treatment or are particularly severe, brain stimulation treatments such as electroconvulsive therapy (ECT) or repetitive transcranial magnetic stimulation (rTMS) may be considered.

In addition to treatment, certain measures in daily life may provide supportive benefits. Maintaining regular sleep and eating patterns, engaging in physical activity, maintaining social relationships as much as possible, and sharing feelings with trusted individuals are important. Avoiding alcohol and illicit drug use may also help prevent symptoms from worsening. However, individuals do not need to force themselves to solve everything on their own; depression is not a sign of weakness or a lack of willpower, and seeking professional help is an important part of recovery.

In conclusion, depression is much more than a temporary state of sadness. It is a mental disorder that can affect a person's emotions, thoughts, physical well-being, relationships, and daily functioning, but recovery can be achieved with appropriate support and treatment. If symptoms persist for a prolonged period or significantly interfere with a person's life, it is important to seek help from a healthcare professional.

References:

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